

NAVAL COMBAT IN THE AGE OF SAIL

THE BATTLE OF THE NILE

The victories of British Rear-Admiral Horatio Nelson are among the most renowned examples of naval combat in the age of sailing ships. At Aboukir Bay in 1798, Nelson demolished a French fleet with a typically risky attack that rewrote the rules and tactics of fighting in line.

During the French Revolutionary War, the French fleet escorted General Napoleon Bonaparte's expeditionary force from France to Egypt. By 1 August 1798, 13 French ships of the line and four frigates were anchored at Aboukir Bay, on the Egyptian coast near Alexandria.

Britain's Admiral Lord Nelson had been seeking to intercept Bonaparte's troop convoy, chasing it with his 14 ships of the line. The ships, with one exception, were all 74-gun. On the afternoon of 1 August his lookouts sighted the French fleet, which had adopted an apparently impregnable defensive position: the ships were anchored in line of battle with their port side close to the shore, ready to fire broadsides to starboard. The French fleet was also mainly composed of 74-gun ships, but the fleet's commander, Admiral François-Paul Brueys, had a flagship, *L'Orient*, that was larger than any of the British ships – a massive 120-gun three-decker. Meanwhile, the shallow bay had numerous unmarked sandbanks and shoals that any attacker would need to negotiate with care.

Nelson decided to attack at once, although it was late in the day, focusing on the leading French ships (the van) and the centre of the fleet. Due to wind direction, the ships of the French rear would be unable to join the fight, leaving the British with a local superiority in numbers.

When the British ships sailed into the bay it was nearly sunset. Many French sailors had been ashore and were still hurrying to rejoin their ships. Only one British vessel came to grief on a shoal, a tribute to the quality of Royal Navy seamanship.

Five British ships sailed around the head of the French line and into the shallow water between the French ships and the shore. This manoeuvre took the French entirely by surprise – the gunports on the landward side of their ships were closed. Nelson's ships also sailed into position on the seaward side of the French van, trapping each of the five French ships between a pair of British vessels. Shattered by point-blank broadsides from port and starboard, the French ships were soon in a desperate state.

The British attack on the French centre, however, did not go as well at first. *L'Orient* dismantled *Bellerophon* by firing repeated broadsides, and the crippled ship drifted out of the battle. Nelson, standing in full view on the deck of his flagship *Vanguard* – as was customary – was cut across the forehead by a metal shard.

DESTRUCTION AND DEFEAT

The fighting continued after dark, and the valiant resistance of the French fleet began to fail. At around 10pm, *L'Orient* caught fire and when the flames reached the ship's powder magazine it exploded, scattering burning wreckage over a wide area. Admiral Brueys was already dead, cut almost in half by a cannon shot. During the night the fighting died down, and dawn broke over a scene of desolation: wreckage and dismembered bodies filled the bay. The ships in the rear of the French line had remained mere spectators of the carnage, while several French vessels had slipped away in the night. Nelson had destroyed two French ships of the line and captured nine.

